

PvA Position paper on use of AI for simplification of municipal communication.

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Dutch municipalities increasingly rely on B1-targeted language guidelines to make official communication more accessible. At the same time, large language models (LLMs) and AI-based rewriting tools are emerging as attractive solutions to support text simplification, quality control, and workflow efficiency. This position paper focuses on the Municipality of Oostzaan, where AI-assisted writing is being explored for municipal letters that must be both legally correct and understandable for diverse resident groups.

The central concern is not whether AI can simplify texts to a B1 reading level, but what such simplification might mean for the long-term linguistic richness and expressive precision of Dutch civic language. The paper draws on three bodies of information, documented declines in Dutch literacy and reading comprehension, critiques of using CEFR levels and automated CEFR classifiers as proxies for intrinsic text complexity, and emerging research on the homogenizing effects of LLM-generated language on style, vocabulary, and thought. The research aims to build on the practical experiences reported by municipal staff to create a clear and more grounded picture of the problem and whether the proposed solution makes sense.

The methodological approach is research driven, rather than evaluating model architectures or accuracy, the paper examines how institutionalised AI-driven simplification could interact with existing sociolinguistic trends. The working hypothesis is that structural reliance on AI for B1-level rewriting risks accelerating linguistic flattening while leaving underlying educational and structural causes of incomprehension largely unaddressed. The position developed in the final article will therefore argue for cautious, conditional, and preferably diagnostic uses of AI, and will explore alternative ways in which AI might support the Dutch government and municipalities goal for equitable communication without eroding linguistic resilience and skill.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: AI text simplification, municipal communication, Dutch language, B1 language level, linguistic homogenization, large language models, language policy

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1 Introduction

1.1 Municipal communication, accessibility and AI

Municipal communication in the Netherlands increasingly aims for accessible language, often targeting B1-level readability to ensure broad comprehensibility among citizens. In parallel, AI-assisted writing tools and large language models are emerging as potential aids for simplifying official texts and supporting writers in municipal workflows. While these developments promise efficiency and improved accessibility, they also raise questions about the impact of AI-mediated simplification on Dutch civic language.

This paper examines whether structural adoption of AI-driven B1 simplification in municipal communication may unintentionally contribute to linguistic homogenization, reduced expressive richness and literacy. Situated in the project context of the Municipality of Oostzaan, it asks whether such tools ultimately support equitable communication or risk weakening the linguistic resilience and nuance of Dutch over time.

1.2 B1 policy and real-world communication challenges

Municipalities are responsible for communicating clearly, accurately, and accessibly with their residents. The Municipality of Oostzaan aims to formulate official communication in a way that is understandable to as many citizens as possible, using internal guidelines that target B1 language level. B1 is widely promoted in Dutch public communication as a default standard: policy and health-communication guidelines state that most people in the Netherlands (roughly 80 percent) can understand texts at B1 level, while around 20 percent still experience difficulties at this level.[13, 33, 35, 39] These recommendations are embedded in national guidance on clear and inclusive communication, in which B1 is explicitly endorsed as the preferred level for many government websites and services.[9, 10, 23] Large national bodies such as the Belastingdienst and Toeslagen likewise commit to using simple language as part of broader programmes to improve service delivery and citizen trust.[6, 7] As a result, B1 functions as a *de facto* policy benchmark for accessible public communication. Employees are trained to write according to the B1 level standard and Oostzaan's own writing guide, and to review each other's letters.

In practice, this ideal is difficult to realize. Rewriting texts is labor-intensive and not all employees have the same level of linguistic expertise or familiarity with the municipal *schrijfwijzer*. The B1 guideline itself is not an operationally precise metric but a broad label staff must interpret based on their own perception of what B1 language looks like in a given context.

Practitioners report that several citizen groups frequently struggle with the clarity of official letters, including residents with a migration background, NT2 speakers, refugees and recent arrivals, and individuals with LVB. Importantly, even highly educated citizens can experience difficulty when confronted with specialised administrative or legal language. Misunderstandings do not always result from low general language competence but can stem from legal phrasing, abstract terminology, and institutional formulations. Communicative accessibility is therefore a broader issue that affects multiple citizen profiles.

In this context, the use of AI writing tools is being considered to support and improve the municipal communication process. Text simplification is one avenue, but not the only one. Large language models could be used to highlight complex passages, flag jargon, and propose alternatives or check consistency with the municipality's *schrijfwijzer*. They could also provide concrete feedback to employees on which aspects of a text are not aligned with B1 guidelines, instead of silently rewriting the letter. This paper examines whether introducing AI-based rewriting and B1-targeted simplification in municipal communication is desirable and responsible given the broader goal of equitable communication.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Literacy in the Netherlands and accessibility pressures

A growing body of research shows that Dutch language skills and reading comprehension have been declining. Literature on language proficiency in the Netherlands indicates that Dutch language competence has weakened across segments of the population and that younger generations increasingly experience difficulty engaging with formal or bureaucratic Dutch.[14, 20–22, 29–31, 40, 41] International evaluations such as PISA document reduced reading performance among Dutch 15-year-olds and a growing proportion of students falling below baseline proficiency.[29, 31, 41] EU monitoring and comparative educational statistics confirm that the Netherlands faces persistent challenges in reading literacy.[14, 30] National reports from the Inspectorate of Education indicate that many pupils do not reach the intended reference levels.[20–22, 40] The Court of Audit highlights that around 2.5 million adults in the Netherlands have difficulties with reading and numeracy.[1] This decline in literacy contributes to institutional pressure to lower the linguistic threshold of government communication.[10, 11, 23]

2.2 CEFR and its limitations as a proxy for text complexity

The Common European Framework of Reference for Languages was developed to describe the proficiency of language learners and to provide a common descriptive basis for ability levels such as A1 to C2.[12] It was not designed as an analytic tool for intrinsic textual complexity. Researchers have highlighted the limitations of using the CEFR scale for such purposes. Weir argues that CEFR scales do not fully account for contextual processing variables.[42] Automated CEFR-based classification tools have shown inconsistent scoring for identical texts, which raises questions about reliability for policy use.[37] Morales examined grammar-based complexity patterns across CEFR bands and found that structural complexity does not align cleanly with CEFR levels.[27] The result is a practical situation where subjective judgement is combined with a scale that is misaligned with municipal communication goals.

2.3 AI-generated language and linguistic homogenization

Research into AI-assisted writing indicates that reliance on language models is associated with reduced stylistic diversity and convergence toward model-preferred linguistic forms. Large language models tend to favor predictable syntactic patterns, standardized phrasing, limited vocabulary variation, and statistically dominant language forms. Empirical comparisons have identified measurable reductions in lexical diversity and syntactic richness in AI-generated text.[16, 17] Studies in educational contexts find that while AI support improves correctness, it also encourages mechanical phrasing and uniformity.[15, 24, 34] Simplification research shows benefits for comprehension but also confirms a reduction in textual richness.[2, 4, 19, 26] Several authors argue that widespread use of LLMs risks homogenizing language and thought.[5, 32, 38] Cognitive studies suggest that these linguistic patterns can influence how users allocate attention in reading and writing.[25]

For Dutch, this concern may be intensified. Standardized formal Dutch dominates state communication, and Dutch does not have the same global linguistic reinforcement through international media that English has. Observations align with broader concerns that dominant-language technologies reduce linguistic diversity.[36]

2.4 Historical perspectives on institutional language shaping

The introduction of AI-based language rewriting by governments can be compared to historical examples where institutional language management influenced linguistic environments. In Singapore, policies favouring English and selected mother tongues have contributed to language shift.[8, 28] In the Philippines, the predominance of English and Filipino in education and governance has marginalised other languages.[3, 18] These cases show how structural language decisions by public institutions can reshape language use at societal scale.

2.5 Research gap and objectives

There is currently limited research on the long-term linguistic impact of AI-generated language on Dutch, especially in institutional communication. While anecdotal and adjacent studies exist, there is no established consensus on the societal-linguistic consequences of deploying AI to shape civic language. This gap justifies both the inquiry and the cautionary stance of the paper.

The purpose of this position paper is to investigate whether the adoption of AI-based rewriting and B1-targeted language simplification in municipal communication is a desirable and responsible development. The paper first aims to build an informed understanding of the current state of Dutch language proficiency and linguistic stability in society, including concerns about declining mastery of formal Dutch and increasing influence from English and simplified digital discourse. In addition, it examines what is known about how AI-generated language affects linguistic variation and whether similar concerns have been studied in other national contexts. When direct Dutch-specific research is lacking, insights from broader international studies or AI-language research on dominant languages such as English will be used as analogical evidence.

The goal is not merely descriptive but analytical. The gathered insights will be combined to help support a grounded argument about the suitability, risks, and responsibilities associated with introducing AI-mediated language into official government communication. Particular attention will be given to whether AI might reinforce existing trends of linguistic flattening, thereby accelerating a reduction in expressive precision and conceptual depth rather than mitigating communication barriers, and whether lowering the language level now could lead to more problems down the road if literacy continues to decline.

2.6 Research questions and hypothesis

The working hypothesis is that the use of AI-based language simplification in municipal communication will accelerate existing trends of linguistic degradation and narrowing of expressive capacity in Dutch and will not fundamentally solve underlying comprehension issues, potentially postponing or deepening structural language-education challenges.

Alongside this hypothesis, alternative possibilities will also be considered. One possibility is that the linguistic impact of AI may be neutral and that AI-driven simplification neither accelerates nor inhibits linguistic richness at scale. Another hypothesis is that AI might provide a net positive effect when used selectively, for example as a diagnostic or advisory tool rather than an autonomous rewriter, supporting clarity without diminishing expressive or cognitive depth.

The main research question guiding this work is:

To what extent does the use of AI-driven simplification to B1 level in municipal communication pose a risk to the linguistic richness and precision of the Dutch language?

To answer the main question, several sub-questions will structure the inquiry:

- (1) What trends exist in the development of Dutch language proficiency and linguistic richness within the Netherlands, and which groups are most affected?
- (2) What is known about the effects of AI-generated language on linguistic diversity, expressiveness, and stylistic variation?
- (3) How have other countries responded to similar linguistic shifts and pressures, particularly in contexts where a dominant language exerts structural influence over local languages?
- (4) To what extent do AI tools used for rewriting follow statistically dominant linguistic patterns, and how might this influence long-term language evolution?
- (5) What alternative uses of AI in municipal communication might support clarity without encouraging linguistic simplification or homogenization?

3 Methodology

3.1 Overall approach and scope

The scope of this paper is deliberately conceptual and normative rather than technical. It does not investigate the engineering, training, or deployment of AI systems, nor does it evaluate model accuracy or performance. Instead, it critically examines the cultural, linguistic, and societal implications of automating language simplification in public administration and asks whether such tools address communication challenges or risk accelerating deeper structural issues in language competence and linguistic resilience.

The methodological approach of this position paper is inquiry-driven and reflective rather than experimental or technical. Rather than testing a specific system or optimisation strategy, the paper looks at different bodies of evidence to evaluate the plausibility and severity of linguistic risks associated with AI-driven simplification in municipal communication.

3.2 Target audience and implications for methodology

The primary intended readers of this work are municipal communication practitioners, policy advisors, and administrative decision makers. These groups play a direct role in shaping and approving the language of public-facing communication and in deciding whether and how AI tools should be adopted within municipal workflows. The paper is therefore written to support these readers in making informed decisions about AI use in communication, to help them understand potential linguistic risks, and to encourage cautious and reflective adoption where appropriate.

This influences the methodology in several ways:

- (1) Complex linguistic and AI concepts are presented using plain-language explanations rather than technical or mathematical formalism.
- (2) Analytical focus is placed on real-world governance implications and communication outcomes rather than model internals or computational performance metrics.
- (3) The argument deliberately presents more than one plausible interpretation of the evidence, so that readers can weigh competing hypotheses and are not encouraged to treat speculative projections as established fact.
- (4) The overall stance acknowledges that the adoption of AI in municipal workflows cannot realistically be fully prevented and therefore aims to support cautious use, encouraging readers to consider alternative, lower-risk applications of AI that prioritise diagnostic support and human judgement.

To support this audience, the information will be structured so that technical aspects are simplified to what is directly relevant for municipal practice. Where appropriate, abstract concepts are explained through short examples and analogies that link AI behaviour to familiar communication processes. Key ideas are highlighted in the text and, where useful, supported by simple visual elements such as tables, schematic figures, or other illustrative layouts that can aid understanding without requiring specialised technical background. In this way, the methodology is not only about how evidence is gathered but also about how it is framed to invite critical reflection and informed decision making by a non-technical administrative audience.

As part of this audience-oriented approach, a late draft of the paper will be shared with the former Zaanstad jurist as a representative reader. She will be asked to read the text, answer a few open-ended questions about the core message and perceived risks, and write a brief summary in her own words. This small, qualitative check is intended to test whether the main argument and nuances are understandable for a non-technical municipal professional.

3.3 Evidence collection and analysis

The evidence will be gathered and analysed in four stages that correspond directly to the structure of the literature review.

1. Dutch literacy trends and language resilience. The first stage reviews evidence on Dutch language proficiency, declining literacy, and reduced reading capacity across the population. This includes national and international assessments of reading performance,[1, 14, 21, 22, 29–31, 40, 41] research on comprehensibility of government texts,[10, 11, 23] and sociolinguistic literature on structural language change.[36] Where relevant, international comparisons will be used to contextualise Dutch developments, for example language policy in Singapore and the Philippines.[3, 8, 18, 28]

2. Examination of B1-level communication and CEFR limitations. The second stage investigates the role of B1 as the institutional standard for accessibility in Dutch municipal communication and examines the suitability of CEFR as a proxy for text complexity. This includes both official policy interpretations and critiques on validity and interpretability.[12, 27, 37, 42] The analysis focuses on practical ambiguity in applying B1 requirements to nuanced legal-administrative communication.

3. Behaviour of AI writing systems. The third component examines how LLMs generate text, including tendencies toward standardized phrasing and statistically dominant linguistic norms. This stage draws on empirical work examining lexical diversity, syntactic richness, simplification behaviours,[2, 4, 15–17, 19, 24, 26, 34] as well as research demonstrating the homogenizing effect of AI-mediated writing on cognitive processes and textual form.[5, 25, 32, 38]

4. Linguistic homogenization and human linguistic behaviour. The final stage looks at how language simplification and AI-shaped linguistic norms might influence long-term linguistic expressiveness, vocabulary depth, and cognitive function in language use. Particular attention is given to risks of reduced expressive variability and diminished personal linguistic identity, synthesising insights from both linguistic and cognitive studies.[25, 36, 38]

Throughout the analysis, the hypothesis that AI-driven simplification may accelerate linguistic flattening is treated as a tentative premise rather than a predetermined conclusion. It remains possible that the research will indicate the risks are manageable, or that AI may be more appropriate as a diagnostic feedback tool rather than a rewriting engine. Conversely, evidence may support a more restrictive stance. The final position will therefore emerge from converging evidence rather than presupposition, seeking nuanced guidance for cautious and responsible use of AI in municipal communication.

3.4 Considerations and potential discussion

The discussion component of this paper will explicitly acknowledge the uncertainty and evolving nature of the topic. The widespread public use of large language models is only a few years old, with tools such as ChatGPT entering mainstream use in late 2022 and organizational integration still in its early stages. Governmental applications, particularly for official communication, are even less mature. Because of this, some of the findings will likely be inconclusive or indirectly inferential rather than definitive.

The discussion will therefore identify where evidence remains limited, where linguistic effects are still emerging, and where published research may be contradictory or insufficiently longitudinal. Rather than treating concerns as predetermined conclusions, the paper will distinguish clearly between established empirical patterns and forward-looking projections. Readers will be encouraged to consider multiple plausible interpretations and to critically reflect on the implications for municipal practice rather than accepting a singular viewpoint.

This will re-affirm that the position ultimately taken in the paper is a position based on the research rather than a fact. The conclusion is intended to guide careful policy consideration by highlighting uncertainties and

risks while recognizing that AI integration into communication workflows is likely to proceed in some form. The aim is to support informed, cautious adoption and to stimulate thinking about alternative applications and safeguards that preserve linguistic resilience rather than diminish it.

Proposed Outline for Position Paper

- (1) **Summary**
 - Brief statement of the paper's position and key findings.
 - Introduce the core question: whether AI-based writing is suitable for municipal communication given linguistic concerns.
- (2) **Introduction: Motivation and Identified Gap**
 - Contextualise the importance of municipal communication.
 - Note the emergence of AI writing tools in government workflows.
 - Identify the gap concerning long-term linguistic impacts in the Dutch context.
- (3) **Literature Review**
 - (a) **Research questions**
 - State the core and supporting questions that guide the analysis.
 - (b) **Dutch literacy decline**
 - Summarise evidence of reduced literacy levels.
 - Mention English influence on Dutch usage.
 - Briefly compare with similar international cases.
 - (c) **B1 communication standard and limitations**
 - Explain why B1 is used in Dutch public communication.
 - Note CEFR constraints when applied to text complexity.
 - Highlight practical ambiguity and interpretive variance in application.
 - (d) **AI writing systems and output tendencies**
 - Outline how LLMs generate simplified and statistically dominant phrasing.
 - Explain the role of training corpora in shaping output style.
 - (e) **Linguistic homogenization**
 - Describe the risk of convergence toward standardized phrasing.
 - Note potential long-term effects on expressive capacity and vocabulary depth.
- (4) **Possible Scenarios**
 - Low risk: neutral linguistic impact.
 - High risk: acceleration of language flattening and reduced diversity.
 - Cautious adoption: AI as supportive tool rather than primary author.
- (5) **Final Position and Recommendation**
 - Present the paper's argued stance grounded in evidence.
 - Link the conclusion to the findings of the literature and scenario evaluation.
- (6) **Conclusion**
 - Brief reflection that ties back to research objectives.
 - Emphasise societal relevance and long-term language resilience.
- (7) **Discussion and Limitations**
 - Acknowledge uncertainty and inferential reasoning.
 - Clarify where evidence is emerging or incomplete.
 - Encourage further research and deliberate, cautious use rather than binary acceptance or rejection.

Planning

Table 1. Planning for Position Paper Development

Week	Dates	Tasks	Deliverables
1	29 Nov – 8 Dec	• Collect literature • Identify gaps • Refine questions • Map sources to sections	• Refined research questions • Structured literature overview
2	9 Dec – 15 Dec	• Study literacy decline • Draft literacy subsection	• Literacy subsection draft
3	16 Dec – 22 Dec	• Study B1 and CEFR • Draft CEFR subsection	• B1/CEFR subsection draft
–	23 Dec – 3 Jan	• Winter break • No planned work	• Rest period
4	4 Jan – 8 Jan	• Study AI writing behaviour • Draft AI subsection • Prepare presentation	• AI subsection draft • Presentation prep
–	9 Jan	• Hold presentation • Collect feedback	• Feedback and action list
5	10 Jan – 15 Jan	• Study homogenization • Draft subsection • Integrate sections	• Draft full literature review
6	16 Jan – 19 Jan	• Apply feedback • Adjust structure • Identify discussion points	• Revised draft outline
7	20 Jan – 23 Jan	• Clarity test with former Zaanstad jurist • Ask open questions and collect written summary • Refine wording based on feedback	• Qualitative clarity feedback • Audience-fit draft
8	24 Jan – 26 Jan	• Create visuals • Integrate visuals • Refine introduction and method	• Visual-enhanced draft • Polished intro and method
9	27 Jan – 29 Jan	• Write conclusion • Write abstract and summary • Validate argument balance	• Near-final draft
10	30 Jan	• Final language check • Verify layout and refs • Submit	• Submitted paper

4 Citations and Bibliographies

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